



The Sandbox is a good place to start if you're not sure of Wiki syntax. This is one page where it's OK to make mistakes

Running Wikis

Adding a page, or modifying one on someone else's Wiki is the easiest way to get started, but advanced users—and those with their own Web servers—can set up their own Wiki. Even companies can set up a Wiki to provide an online version of a bulletin board, databases inside a corporate LAN that can be updated on the fly, research documents, etc. Those with large families can set up a family Wiki as an entertaining method of communication and keeping in touch; rather than the



Sites to visit

<http://c2.com/cgi/wiki/>: Created by Ward Cunningham, the Portland Pattern Repository was the first ever Wiki. It was started as a place to share programming code, thoughts and to find patterns in programming.

www.greencheese.org: This crazy Wiki wants to figure out what our grandparents meant when they told us, "The moon is made of green cheese!" It has a username and password login system, but anyone can sign up to use this Wiki.

<http://en.wikipedia.org/>: Wikipedia is a popular online encyclopaedia. The best thing is that in true Wiki style, anyone can add, change, or delete the definitions mentioned here. Try the 'Random Page' link for a laugh—it displays a definition of a term, chosen at random.

<http://www.usemod.com/cgi-bin/mb.pl>: MeatBall Wiki aims to be an online meta-community—a common meeting place for the online community.

<https://musircd.dagur.com/phpwiki/>: Visit this Wiki to learn or teach people about IRC and IRC Daemons—mostly Linux based daemons such as Hybrid and MusIRCD.

Wiki Etiquette

- Never use smileys or IM terms such as LOL, etc. Wikizens consider themselves a cultured bunch, and using slang makes them think you're an inferior species.
- Think three thousand five hundred and eighty-six times before you edit a page and add your thoughts. Chances are that a few minutes or hours after you edit a page, there will be someone or the other scrutinising your work and trying to find a typo. That's just the way it is!
- Try not to intervene in a topic or discussion you know nothing about.
- Try to use a Wiki's SandBox page and experiment there with the formatting before you actually start editing—this can save you a lot of embarrassment later.

- Never delete what's written, unless it's on a page you created and isn't of importance anymore.
- Creating pages that are out of topic on a Wiki is considered WikiSquatting—another form of rude behaviour. For example, on a Wiki dedicated to programming, creating a page dedicated to Metallica is sure to get a few verbal
- Don't create a personal Web site on a Wiki, or advertise yours unnecessarily. This is acceptable only if your Web site has something meaningful and pertinent to say. Commercial use of a Wiki's features is discourteous, and such pages are likely to be deleted pretty quickly.

mundane e-mail, snail-mail, or the IM. The possibilities are endless, and Wiki could be as addictive as IRC, or IM chatting.

There are hundreds of Wiki clones, and choosing one can be a tedious exercise. There are those that require integration with Web server software such as Apache, while others contain an inbuilt server. Then there's the problem of choosing one that's optimised for your operating system. All in all, finding the best Wiki server software can be a daunting task, resulting in hours of reading feature sets. Since all the fun of a Wiki lies in using it, and not setting it up, we decided to be lazy and look for the easiest and fastest to set up Wiki software. Our search led us to WikiServer that is a newbie's delight. Download the 141 Kilobyte file from <http://www.tinyted.net/eddie/wiki/>, unzip it, double-click on the .EXE file, open Internet Explorer and navigate to <http://localhost/>, or <http://127.0.0.1/>. Now, you can configure your Wiki using only your browser. The server runs as an MS-DOS window, so as long as it's open, it is running.

Those interested in advanced complex servers that support ASP, Java, Perl, CGI, etc., can check out the really long list of Wiki engines at <http://www.c2.com/cgi/wiki?WikiEngines>. Here, you can search for the one that best suits the programming language, or the operating system you are working with.



WikiServer is by far the easiest Wiki HTTP server available. Just double-click the EXE file, point your browser to <http://localhost> and start creating your very own Wiki.

AWikiWikiEnd

Whether it's for fun, intellectual discourse, meeting people, discussing ideas, or just to blow your own trumpet, you're sure to find a Wiki that you can fit right into. Even if you don't, you can always start one. Wiki is growing in popularity, and is here to stay. Between all the hot air, stuffiness, holier-than-thou attitudes and intellectual braggarts, you're sure to find a few buddies. Sure, you'll make enemies and friends, have a few verbal fisticuffs and squabbles, but overall you're sure to leave with a better vocabulary, higher sense of understanding... and two black eyes. Next time, fling a copy of Webster's dictionary at your assailant's head! ■

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